Muslims. They frequently share the same barracks for their temple and the mosque.

The fifth event was the regimental reunion held in April 2007. It was the first reunion held with the army chief as the colonel of the regiment, and evoked great bonhomie and regimental spirit.

Finally, I would like to place on record the magnificent contribution of the House of Kolhapur, a royal family which has descended from the great warrior king Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. The present maharaja, Shahu Chhatrapati, has rendered yeoman service to the Maratha Light Infantry, following the footsteps of his illustrious father, Major General Shahaji Chhatrapati. During the Second World War, his grandfather, Rajaram Chhatrapati Maharaj, made available his palace guard battalion (which was known as Rajaram Rifles and later 19 Maratha LI) to help in the war effort. During my tenure as the army chief, in a touching honour ceremony held at Kolhapur on 29 May 2006, the Maharaja Saheb presented me with a traditional silver sword, which now has the pride of place in the Regimental Centre Officers' Mess. Shahu Chhatrapati has made it a point to visit the Maratha battalions even in remote field areas to boost the morale of our soldiers, and remains in personal contact with the officer corps of the regiment.

In 2009 he visited Arunachal Pradesh and joined me in unveiling an imposing equestrian statue of Shivaji Maharaj installed at Tawang on the road going to Bumla on the China border, named as Shivaji Marg. He was accompanied by Colonel Sambhaji Patil of the Hyderabadis, who was the CO when the road was initially constructed under the overall responsibility of 22 Maratha LI. The officers and men worked day and night alongwith engineers and completed a 30-kilometre road in seven months in high altitude and rocky terrain.

During my tenure as the colonel of the regiment and army chief, Colonel Vasanth V., CO of 9 Maratha LI, laid down his life as a brave warrior. Fighting against the terrorists along the line of control in the Uri sector of Kashmir, he became a martyr in the finest traditions of the Indian Army on 31 July 2007. He was decorated with the highest peacetime gallantry award of Ashoka